

CORE FORMULA

Pause the competing task + orient warmly + clear the distraction + one readiness line + listen through. -> Hang on, let me put this down. I want to actually hear this. -> Go on, I'm with you. -> Let me close this so I'm not half-listening. -> You have my attention - what happened? -> I was distracted. Say that again properly, because I do want to hear it.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Phone away, body toward them, and: "Go on, I'm with you."

BEST FOR

- First impressions, greetings, dates, networking, workplace conversations, and one-to-one rapport.
- When someone starts telling you something meaningful, vulnerable, exciting, or frustrating.
- Before asking a deeper question, giving advice, disagreeing, or making a request.
- When someone seems hesitant, guarded, rushed, dismissed, or unsure if you care.
- When you need to rebuild trust after being distracted or interrupting.
- Digital-to-live transitions: before moving from laptop or phone work into an actual conversation.

PHRASE BANK

Quick defaults · Quick defaults

- "Go on, I'm with you."
- "I'm listening."
- "Tell me."
- "What happened?"
- "I'm here."
- "Give me the proper version."

Warm and human · Warm and human

- "Hang on, let me put this away. I want to actually hear this."
- "That sounds important. I'm with you."
- "I don't want to half-listen to this."
- "Say that again - I want to catch it properly."
- "You've got my attention."
- "I'm not rushing you."

Social / dating · Social / dating

- "Okay, that sounds like the real story."
- "I want the full version."
- "That deserves actual attention."
- "You have my curiosity now."
- "I'm listening - no shortcut version."
- "That sounds like it mattered."

Professional / leadership · Professional / leadership

- "Let me close this laptop so I can focus."
- "Give me the headline, then I'll ask a few questions."
- "I want to understand before I respond."
- "Let's pause the task for a moment and hear this properly."

- "This sounds worth slowing down for."
- "I'll stop typing for this."

High-status / busy person · High-status / busy person

- "I'll be concise. What's the key thing you need me to understand?"
- "I've got you for a few minutes - I'll focus."
- "Let me get the main point clearly."
- "I'll stop you if I need clarification, but I'm with you."
- "What's the decision point?"
- "I'll give this my attention and keep it tight."

Digital / text · Digital / text

- "I want to reply properly, not quickly. I'll come back to this tonight."
- "I'm reading this properly now."
- "This deserves a better reply than a rushed one."
- "I saw this and want to give it proper attention."
- "Can I reply properly after work?"
- "I don't want to half-answer this."

Conflict / repair · Conflict / repair

- "I think I was half-listening. Let me reset."
- "You're right - I was distracted. Say it again and I'll listen properly."
- "Before I defend myself, I want to understand what landed badly."
- "Let me slow down. What do I need to hear?"
- "I don't want to miss the point because I'm reacting."
- "I'm going to stop multitasking and hear this."

Shy or guarded person · Shy or guarded person

- "No rush."
- "Take your time."
- "You don't have to make it neat."
- "Start wherever it makes sense."
- "We can keep this simple."
- "You can say as much or as little as you want."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the move mechanically or too often, the same way every time.
Better: Uses the smallest useful version and then listens.
Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts to the response.
2. Weak: Talks about listening - "I'm really listening" - while still half-distracted.
Better: Performs one clear behavioural move: phone down, body turned.
Best: Makes the move feel like ordinary skilled conversation rather than a signal.
3. Weak: Holds fixed eye contact and waits for the person to perform.
Better: Gives them the floor, then genuinely listens to the answer.
Best: Reads how it lands and eases off the moment it starts to feel like pressure.

DECISION TREE

If They shift into something that matters - a cue this move is built for.

Use the minimum viable move: clear the distraction and give them the floor.
"Go on, I'm with you."

If No real cue - it is ordinary chat.

Just listen normally, or reach for a warmer opener instead.
"How's your day actually been?"

If The move opened them up.

Stay with the thread once; don't stack questions on top of it.

"So the hard part was the uncertainty, not the work."

If They tighten or seem put on the spot.

Reduce intensity - soften your face, ease back, or return to the task.

"No pressure if you don't want to go into it."

If There is distress or urgency.

For distress, add warmth; for urgency, drop the move and act.

"Tell me what you need right now."

If You have already signalled attention once.

Don't repeat it mechanically - switch to a summary, a clean request, or an ordinary contribution.

"So where does that leave things?"

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Use the smallest natural version so the person feels heard, not analysed. — "Go on, I'm with you."

Professional discussion

Keep it concise and tie the move to the task, decision or concern. — "Let me close this laptop - give me the headline."

Conflict or objection

Add validation and reduce speed; don't weaponise the focus. — "I'm going to stop multitasking and actually hear this."

Digital message

Write one clean sentence; skip the stacked questions. — "This deserves a proper reply - can I come back to you tonight?"

Shy or guarded person

Make the move lighter, more tentative and lower pressure. — "No rush - start wherever it makes sense."

High-status or busy person

Keep the wording brief, grounded and useful. — "I've got you for a few minutes - what's the key thing?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They are shy, anxious, culturally uncomfortable with direct eye contact, or clearly need more space.
- The situation calls for lightness, movement or parallel activity rather than intense face-to-face focus.
- You would only be performing focus to look attentive, not to actually listen better.
- You cannot really give attention right now - better to name the limit and arrange a proper moment.
- The person needs safety, privacy, silence or direct practical help instead.
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency response takes priority.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Through the day, notice three moments where someone shifts from small talk into something that matters - the voice drops, they hesitate, they check your face. Just notice them; change nothing yet.

Day 2 — Clear the competition

In one low-stakes conversation, physically put the competing thing down - phone face-down, laptop closed - before you reply. Notice what changes in how the person talks.

Day 3 — One readiness line

Write your own minimum viable version of Full-Attention Signal for three ordinary comments, then say each out loud once in a normal voice. Cut any line that sounds clever, therapeutic or corporate.

Day 4 — Use it live, once

In a real conversation, use the smallest version once - phone away, body turned, "Go on, I'm with you" - then stop and listen to the whole answer without composing your reply.

Day 5 — Calibrate

Use the move again, but watch how it lands. If they open up, stay with the thread once. If they tighten, soften your face and ease off. Note which happened and why.

Day 6 — Three settings

Run one low-stakes version, one professional version tied to the task, and one recovery line after a missed read. Notice how the wording has to change with the context.

Day 7 — Make it invisible

Use the move once where you would normally half-listen, aiming for it to feel like ordinary conversation rather than a technique. Afterwards, ask whether the person seemed clearer or managed.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use the move because the cue was there, or because I wanted to look like a good listener?
- Did my behaviour actually remove the competition - phone down, screen closed, body turned?
- Was my wording shorter than my instinct?
- Did I stop and listen to the whole answer, or start composing my reply?
- Did the person have more room after my move, or less?
- Did I ease off the moment it started to feel like pressure?